

with them. That's what can happen when you all get together with the intention of listening and learning. (*Santiago nods and sits quietly with his eyes closed.*)

The therapist focuses on facilitating this Self-to-part connection.



The therapist guided Santiago to notice and connect with both teams—the soothing firefighters and the worried managers. Although the concept was new to Santiago, and he didn't have any expectations about how it would help, he noticed that making a connection with both teams quickly calmed his parts, which was a reinforcing outcome within the session as well as for future Self-to-part connections.

DE-ESCALATING THE MANAGER-FIREFIGHTER POLARITY

As we've covered, manager and firefighter parts live in the same system and share the same desire to keep the system functioning. We don't choose between them; we build relationships with both teams. As critical managers feel understood and calm down, beleaguered firefighters get some relief. The reverse is also true. As firefighters tone down risky behavior, controlling and cautious managers get some relief too. Just as these two teams escalate together, they de-escalate together, and the sense of inner community builds. A client might say, for instance, "It feels good to understand this about myself" at the end of a session. Or they might validate a dominant manager by saying, "I feel sorry for my perfectionist. He never ever gets rest or appreciation." As the client develops warm, collaborative Self-to-part relationships inside, they also gain appreciation for the adaptive intentions of each protective team.

For example, Thea was a twenty-eight-year-old Greek American, partnered, heterosexual, cisgender woman who was currently in graduate school. She reported that she often drank large quantities of wine starting early in the day and also got high on cannabis. Recently, she missed a class she was supposed to teach because she was too intoxicated. Additionally, she was arguing with her boyfriend, Tom, frequently.

DE-ESCALATING A POLARITY



Therapist: I know it's not easy to talk about all this. It sounds like the drinking and getting high are really a worry for you right now, especially since you missed your class.

Thea's Firefighter: Yeah, I mean I've always partied plenty, which is fine. Who cares? But I really got in trouble with my graduate adviser for missing my class. That was pretty fucked up. And my boyfriend is on me now, too, which is pissing me off. Like he's not getting loaded? But I thought, okay, fine, I'll ease off for a while. And I was doing really good, ya know? Like even over the weekend. But then I got totally wasted.

She reports on a firefighter-manager polarity, speaking from both sides.

Therapist: What parts do you notice as you speak right now?

Thea's Firefighter: I guess I'm angry. Like why can't I stop? But really, I just want to be able to drink like other people. Like why do I have to give it up? And I'm mad at my boyfriend. Like now he won't get off this.

Therapist: Sounds like tension is building everywhere. We've been talking about how you have two teams that weigh in about alcohol and cannabis. There's the firefighter team, which wants to drink and get high and do whatever it wants to do. And there's the manager team, which make rules, tries to keep you in line, and says when it's time to stop. And now it feels like your graduate adviser and boyfriend are jumping in on the side of the manager team, is that right?

Thea's Firefighter: Yeah, that sums it up. And I'm, like, sick of Tom nagging me.

Therapist: I hear that, and it feels unfair to you since he drinks a ton as well. I have a question for you, though. Does any part of you sometimes, secretly maybe, see his point? Like, do you have a part who says, just inside in your head, *This is going too far*?

Thea's Manager: Well... Yeah, I do. I mean I don't want to get kicked out of graduate school.

Therapist: So, for right now let's just set aside, for a few minutes, what Tom is saying and go to your parts. Is that okay? (*Thea nods.*) Each of your teams wants something good for you. They have roles in your system—and good intentions for you. Let's check in and ask what they want for you. (*Thea nods again.*) Focus first on the manager side and ask this question: If they could have whatever they wanted, if they were in total control of the universe, what would they want for you?

Thea: They want me to get control of my life. They hate when I fuck up!

Therapist: They want you to do what you're supposed to do, right? (*Thea nods.*) Tell them you hear that. They have a point, right? That firefighter team has been messing up lately. You are listening. You are the one who listens to everyone.

Thea: They didn't realize that. Yeah! I'm not one of those firefighters. They're taking that in.

Therapist: Okay, great. And then, when you're ready, get in touch with the drink-and-get-high team. (*Thea nods.*) How are they trying to help when they get you loaded?

Thea: They want me to have some fun, catch a break. Like, feel better! Ya know?

Therapist: Right. Tell them you hear that. You need to have fun. But what, specifically, do you need a break from?

Thea's Firefighter: The whole routine—my whole life! I'm anxious all the time. Like, I'm really behind and I screw up, so I drink Red Bull and stay up all night, but I'm still never really on top of my game. I feel like hell. Like, I ache all over. I've got no one to help me. I just can't do this anymore. (*She weeps.*)

Therapist: So your firefighter team knows this. They see the worried managers who push you, don't they? You're caffeinated and stay up at night, yet you can't get it all done. They're harsh and critical, and then some parts feel really bad and want to give up. And the firefighter team takes you away from all that, yes?

Thea: (*She nods.*) They shut my brain down.

Therapist: All that noise and pressure—the firefighter team is a relief valve that soothes you. What would they need from you for them to feel okay about easing up a bit?

Thea: They think I’m one of the managers; they don’t really see me at all.

Therapist: That’s right, they just know those driven managers. Can you validate them, Thea? Yes, there are many driven parts. However, you aren’t those parts—you’re the calm one who is listening now.

Thea: Okay, yeah, they can tell I’m here. They say they need the managers to ease up and put less pressure on the *shoulds*, ya know? They want me to stop working all night long. They want me to take this Saturday off and ask for a short extension on that lab report. They agree I can wait till later to have a drink.

Therapist: Now check in with the managers. Can they ease up a bit?

Thea: They don’t totally trust me, but they get it. They are really tired. They need a break. I’m letting them know we can work on this together. They’ll see if it gets better if I don’t drink during the day for a while.

Therapist: How does this feel to you, Thea?

Thea: A little calmer! It’s kind of scary, but I’ll give it a try.



In this example, the therapist guided Thea to validate both teams in her addiction polarity and then brokered a harm-reduction deal where each side agreed to ease up a bit. This truce may not hold for long, but it gave Thea more information about the concerns and compulsions of her protectors. The conversation had not yet gotten around to her exiles, but that would come next.

Client Exercise**Welcoming Both Sides of a Polarity**

In your mind's eye, seat yourself at the head of a large table. Be sure that you are *there* at the table, not simply looking at yourself from afar. Then bring to mind a firefighter part (or a team of parts) who your managers don't like or trust. This doesn't have to be your most difficult firefighter part. Visualize this part (or team of parts) sitting on one side of the table. Describe how you feel toward them.

Next, think about the manager parts that are in opposition to those firefighters. Invite them to join you as well, sitting opposite the firefighters at the table. How do you feel toward the manager parts?

If you find that either the manager team or the firefighter team is blending with you, ask what they need from you in order to be willing to separate. Reassure them that you are not the other team; you're the one who listens to everyone. How do they respond to you now?

Let both teams know that there's plenty of space for everyone and that you're not trying to get rid of anyone. You're aware that they all have positive intentions for you. Reassure them that neither side will lose if they let you help. Let them know that you're here for both teams. How do they respond?

Are you still at the head of the table, noticing the teams on either side? If so, what is it like for them to be with you without them taking over? What is it like for you?

Instead of glaring across the table at each other, ask each team to shift their gaze and look toward you. Ask them: Would it be good for them if, going forward, they didn't have to do what they do to handle each other? What if, going forward, they were not alone because they all had you to help out? Would they be interested? Describe how they respond to your attention.

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Therapist Exercise

Draw Your Triangle

Many therapists in this line of work have had a complicated journey with their own firefighter activity. This exercise helps you identify your inner polarities and clarify the connections between your protective teams and your exiles. It invites you to notice and befriend (have an open-hearted exchange with) all of the parts involved: the firefighter parts who enjoy substances or some other escapist or soothing practice, the manager parts who worry about the practice, and the sensitive exiled parts who are being kept out of awareness. By getting familiar with your own polarities, you get better at spotting and accepting your clients' inner conflicts.

As you participate in this exercise, be aware that anxious managers may feel nervous about letting you connect with a firefighter part who they deem potentially out of control, as if just acknowledging its existence will awaken the dragon and invite a flood of shaming. Remind them that you aren't connecting with firefighters to endorse their behavior. Rather, you want to understand their motives and give them new options. By the same token, the Self can help exiles let go of the sense of shamefulness and feel better.

To begin, identify one of your soothing firefighter parts. You can choose a part who is active now or who has helped out in the past, whichever feels most doable for you. Visualize your part engaging in its favorite activity (or activities)—perhaps lying on a sofa, eating, and watching TV; scrolling through social media with a drink in hand; or smoking cannabis (or nicotine). View this part as if through a one-way mirror. Notice its facial expressions. Is it happy, worried, or checked out? Notice its body language. Is it relaxed, tense, exhausted?

How do you feel toward this part? If you are open, ask it what it wants you to know. If you don't feel open, check in with the parts who are blocking you and closing your heart. Ask if they are willing to unblend and trust you. If they are, continue getting to know your firefighter. How is it trying to help you? What function does it have in your inner world? What is it afraid would happen if it didn't do this job for you? Tell it you're listening. Write what you learn in the *firefighters* box at the end of this exercise.

Next, notice any parts who react to this firefighter. These parts may appear in the form of a voice delivering a message or some anxious activation somewhere in your body. You may notice a controlling manager who wants to limit how much time or money you spend engaged in this soothing firefighter activity. You may notice a judgmental manager who says the firefighter part is morally bad, too risk-taking, or weak. You may notice a worried manager who fears the firefighter part will get out of control or who remembers times when the firefighter did go too far. How do you feel toward this reactive manager? If you are not open, check to see if the firefighter part has unblended thoroughly.

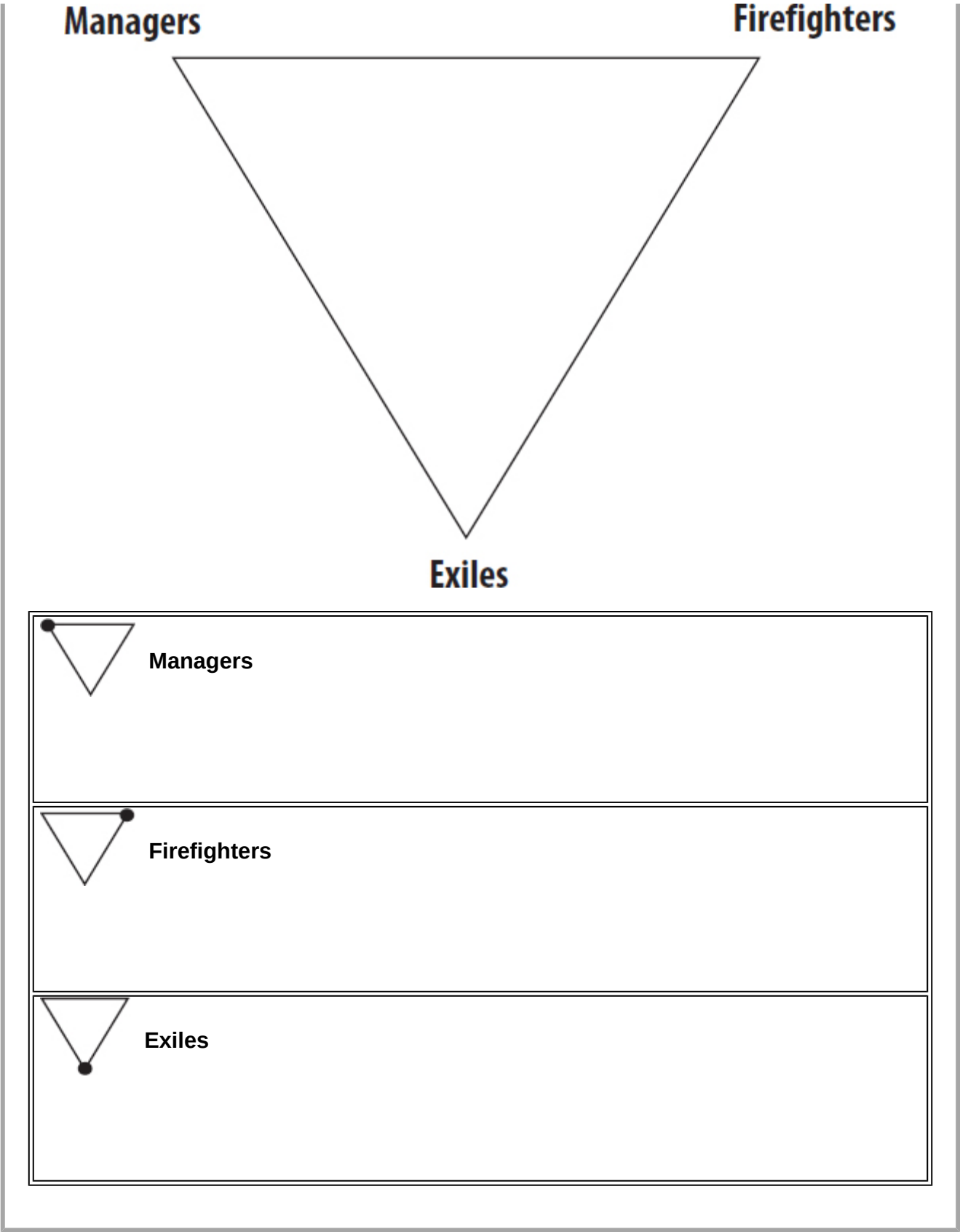
When you are able to feel curious about the manager, ask what it needs you to know. Listen to it closely. What are its concerns? Reassure it that *you* are not the one who is engaging in firefighter behaviors; you are the one who listens to everyone. Acknowledge and validate its concerns—managers often have a good point! What does it want when it comes on so strong? What is it afraid would happen if it relaxed and let you take care of this firefighter part? Write what you're hearing in the *managers* box at the end of this exercise.

Continue by asking each protector who steps forward to describe how it got started in this role. How long has each protector been doing its job? What do they fear would happen if they had to entirely stop doing their jobs? They may express common worries of falling apart, reliving the past, or feeling overwhelmed with shame. Once the protectors have shared their fears, ask them whom it is that they protect. Then invite the protectors to consider this option: What if the Self could take care of the sensitive exiled parts they're protecting? If the protectors agree, ask if it's okay to briefly connect with these exiles. If not, acknowledge their concerns and accept their decision, but ask permission to keep the conversation going and to prove that you could do this safely.

If protectors are willing to step back, welcome and pay attention to the exile. You may see an image of a younger version of yourself, like a snapshot located someplace in your past, or you may simply feel sadness, pain, or the urge to shrink away or hide in your body. Regardless of how the exile shows up, focus on that. Breathe yourself bigger to make room for the part. Let it know that it's not alone because you're here now. What is it like for the exile to have you nearby? How do you feel toward the part now? If a protector shows up, ask it to step back just enough so you can connect again, just for now.

When you feel open again, ask the exile to share one thing that will help it feel understood in this moment. Take that in. If your protectors feel comfortable, spend more time listening to the exile. Pay attention to any sensation of anxiety in your body. If anxious protectors activate, thank the exile for showing up and ask where it would like to go that's safe and comfortable until you can return. Then write what the exile shared with you on the corresponding box marked *Exiles*.

Finally, review the filled-in table as a new map of your parts. Notice each protector team. How do you understand them now? Do they see each other differently? Remind these parts that they don't have to try to fix each other anymore because they can strategize for the good of everyone with you. Point out that you know the exile now, you understand its burdens, and you're here to help. Then send love and compassion to your exile. Thank it for showing up. Appreciate how long it's been waiting for support and how courageous it has been. Let it know that, going forward, you and all these protectors aim to work together to establish safety, and that you will stay in relationship and be available to everyone. No one needs to be alone anymore.



CALMING THE ADDICTIVE POLARITY

As we've been emphasizing, protective parts in addictive systems are in chronic conflict and have no trusted leader. To calm the addictive polarity, we start by identifying, welcoming, and befriending both the functional managers and the risk-taking firefighters. We help both teams separate from the client's Self and talk about their fears, intentions, and addictive processes. The client hears all this for the first time, understands their divided cravings for control and soothing, and sees how they escalate with each other. The client's Self gets traction by developing strong, clear, responsive connections with each part, which encourages them to keep unblending. When a part unblends, clients feel more accepting of themselves and often experience a greater sense of agency: *Okay! Maybe I can do this now.* Parts who feel connected